appears in volume 5.

. In the dismissive words of Akbar's court historian, Abul Fazl.

. 'Mirza' would come to mean 'prince' or young nobleman. Thus, for example, a Rajput heir to Amber is referred to as Mirza Raja Jai Singh in Jahangir's time. At this time, however – and thus in this book – 'mirza' denotes a descendant of Timur.

.Haider Mirza Doghlat, 'Tarikh-i Rashidi', in *The History of India, As Told by Its Own Historians*, trans. H.M. Elliot, vol. 5 (Trübner and Co., 1873). This translation is of extracts from Haider's history. I have also consulted a translation of the full work by E. Denison Ross.

. Sometime between October 1507, when Babur made an unsuccessful attempt to conquer Hindustan, and March 1508, when Babur's first son, Humayun, was born, Babur declared himself 'padishah', or emperor, thus distinguishing himself from the profusion of mirzas – Timurid relatives and rivals – in Central Asia and its outskirts. The title was rather more optimistic than true, both in Babur's case and even more so in that of his luckless son, Humayun, but it stuck through the generations and fulfilled its promise in Akbar.

. Among the deserters were Muhammad Sultan Mirza, to whom Babur had given Kannauj in fief, along with his sons Ulugh Mirza and Shah Mirza. This was not the first time that these Mirzas and their descendants betrayed Babur's family, and it would not be the last.

. *The Akbarnama of Abu'l Fazl*, vol. 1.

. Jouher, *The Tezkereh al Vakiat, or Private Memoirs of Moghul Emperor Humayun by Jouher*, trans. Major Charles Stewart (Oriental Translation Fund, 1832).

. Ibid.

. The horse was borrowed from Tardi Beg, of whom – and of whose horses – more follows.

. Gulbadan, Humayun's sister, relates this exchange in her memoir of her brother's tumultuous reign, the *Humayun-nama*. In it, and not surprisingly, Hindal emerges as the author's clear favourite. Gulbadan Begum, *The History of Humayun (Humayun-nama)*, trans. Annette S. Beveridge (The Asiatic Society, 1902).

. *The Akbarnama of Abu'l Fazl*, vol. 1. Jouher writes that it was Askari who struck Yadgar Nasir with his whip first.

. Haider Mirza Doghlat, *Tarikh-i Rashidi*, trans. H.M. Elliot.

. It may be that Kamran's disinclination to fight on his brother's behalf was at least partly the result of a famous episode from Humayun's life: that of the water carrier whom he made king. Kannauj was the site of Humayun's second defeat at Sher Shah's hands; the first was at Chausa, once again upon the banks of the Ganga. Much of Humayun's camp – including some of his harem – had been swept into the river by Sher Shah's advance; one of his daughters drowned, one of his wives was taken prisoner, and Humayun himself only escaped with the help of a water carrier and his buoyant canteens. As a reward, Humayun declared he would seat the man upon his own throne for a day – a flamboyant and eccentric gesture that deserves its pride of place in popular tellings of Humayun's life and character. At the time, however, and particularly since Sher Shah's advance upon the capital wasn't slowing down, it must have appeared like criminal negligence. 'Gifts and favours of some other kind ought to be the servant's reward,' wrote Kamran to his brother, plainly irritated. 'What propriety is there in setting him on the throne? At a time when Shir Khan is near, what kind of affair is this to engage your Majesty?' (Gulbadan Begum, *The History of Humayun*). Soon after, Humayun left to battle Sher Shah in Kannauj, and a disgusted Kamran packed up and left for Lahore.

. Haider minced no words in his rebuke, by his own account: 'Formerly, when matters could have been arranged with ease, you put obstacles in the way, by your want of constancy and of purpose. At present it is impossible to achieve anything, without encountering untold difficulties.

'I will now lay before you what seems to me your wisest course. It involves great hardships, but it is you who has made hard what was once so easy.' He then proceeded to propose his own conquest of